

Peace Park (Nakajima), Hiroshima

Then-and-now aerial photographs, how the ground was made, and the disasters people chose to remember — compiled automatically from public Japanese government data.



平和記念公園・旧中島地区（広島市中区）

Study area	2.0 km × 1.3 km around 34.3935° N, 132.4530° E
Oldest aerial photograph	1961–1969
Aerial series in this brief	1945–1950, 1961–1969, 1974–1978, 1979–1983, 1987–1990, 2023
Main natural landform	Floodplain and coastal plain (68%)
Former river channels	under 0.5%
Filled, reclaimed or drained land	9.4%
Former sea, river or pond	9.4%
Meiji-era paddies, marsh and flats	sand and gravel 1.6%, tidal flat or beach 1.1%
Disaster memorials within 3 km	1 (landslide or debris flow 1)

What this brief is. A reading aid for comparing the same ground across decades. It shows what the photographs and GSI's land surveys record; it does not describe current conditions, access or opening hours.

What it is not. Not a hazard assessment or a property survey. Landform classes describe typical tendencies of the ground; for present-day risk, read the official hazard map of the municipality.

Edition 2026-09-27. Aerial photographs, landform and Meiji-era lowland data: Geospatial Information Authority of Japan (GSI), processed by Japan Time Atlas. Memorial data: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials, summarised and translated by Japan Time Atlas.

The same ground, 1961–1969 and 2023



1961–1969 aerial photograph — GSI Tiles *ort_old10*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. North is up; the frame is identical in both images.



2023 annual orthophoto — GSI Tiles *nendophoto2023*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. Capture dates within a mosaic can differ from place to place.

How to compare. Anchor on features that rarely move — river banks, rail lines, shrine and temple grounds, main roads — then look for what changed around them. Differences in tone come from film, camera and season, not from the land itself.

The decades in between

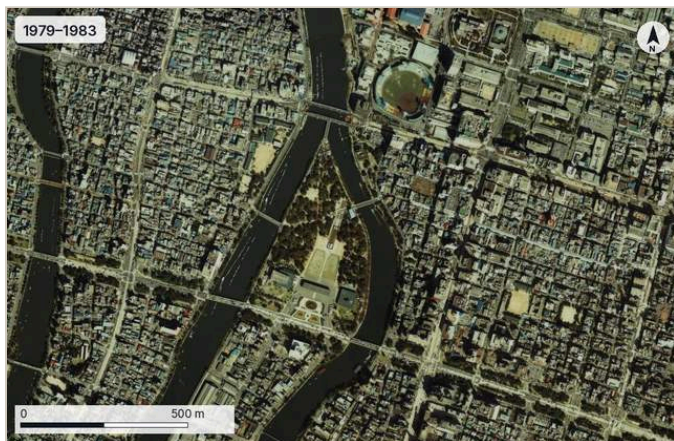
Every further GSI series that covers the same frame, oldest first. Each series is a compilation: photographs within one series were taken on different dates, which is why seams and changes of tone can appear inside a frame.



1945-1950 (US military photography) · GSI Tiles *ort_USA10*, processed



1974-1978 · GSI Tiles *gazo1*, processed



1979-1983 · GSI Tiles *gazo2*, processed



1987-1990 · GSI Tiles *gazo4*, processed

Rivers, shorelines and terraces



Natural landforms as classified by GSI, over a recent aerial photograph in gray. Dark blue outlines mark former river channels.

■ Floodplain and coastal plain 68%	■ Water 21%
■ Natural levee 10%	■ Former water area 9.4%

What the main landforms mean

Floodplain and coastal plain (68%). Low, flat ground of little relief, built from sand and mud left by floods, or former seabed that emerged. River flooding. Ground is softer nearer the coast and shakes somewhat more; liquefaction tendency is strong on coastal plains and somewhat strong on floodplains. Storm surge near the coast.

Natural levee (10%). Long, low ridges 0.5 m to a few metres above their surroundings along present or former rivers, built from sediment dropped by floods. Usually above ordinary floods but can be covered in major ones; strong liquefaction tendency at the edges.

Former water area (9.4%). Land shown by old maps and aerial photographs to have been sea, lake, pond, reservoir or river, later turned into land. Soft ground: very strong liquefaction tendency where filled, strong where drained. Storm surge near the coast.

Former river channel (under 0.5%). A former course of a river, slightly lower than its surroundings, cut off when the river moved and later filled with sand and mud. Floodwater stays longer and drains poorly; soft ground amplifies shaking; where filled or raised, the liquefaction tendency is very strong.

Descriptions translated and condensed from GSI's landform-classification legend. They describe tendencies of each landform type, not the condition of any individual plot.

Fill, reclamation and the fields beneath the town



Hatching: man-made ground as classified by GSI. Teal outlines: former sea, river or pond. Dark blue outlines: former river channels.



GSI “Meiji-era lowland” data, traced from topographic maps of the 1880s-1900s; GSI warns that positions can be off by a considerable distance, especially in the Kanto and Kinki regions. Only low, wet or open ground was traced: towns, dry fields and forest of the period are left blank.

Man-made ground

- Polder (drained reclamation) 6.5%
- Filled and reclaimed land 2.9%

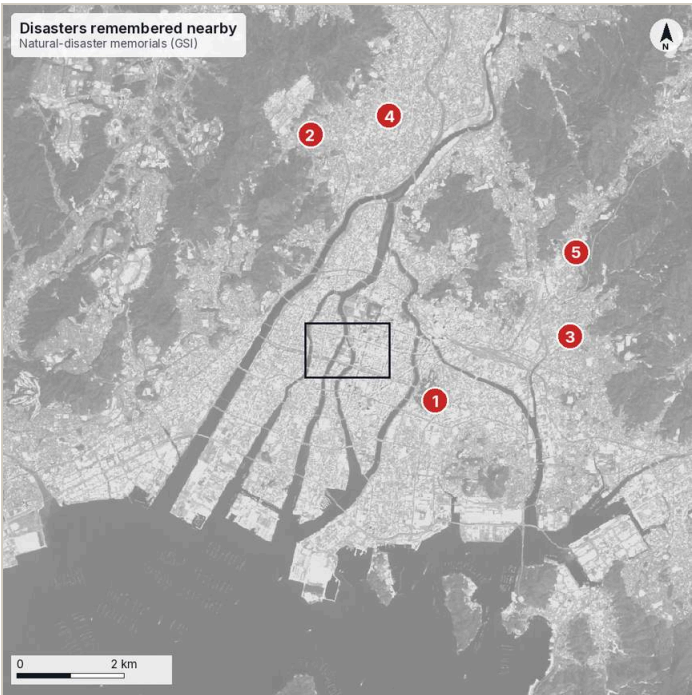
Meiji-era lowland

- River, pond or sea 11%
- Sand and gravel 1.6%
- Tidal flat or beach 1.1%

Polder (drained reclamation) (6.5%). Land made by enclosing water or marsh with embankments and draining it, confirmed from old maps and records. Usually below sea or lake level, so floodwater lingers; storm surge is a particular concern on the coast; soft ground shakes strongly and tends to liquefy.

Filled and reclaimed land (2.9%). Ground raised with fill, land made by dumping soil into the sea, rivers or ponds, or valleys filled in. May flood if not raised enough; on hills, rain or earthquakes can make the fill fail; in lowlands the liquefaction tendency is very strong, especially on filled sea, lake or river beds.

Memorials to natural disasters nearby



Numbered memorials; the black rectangle is the study area of this brief. Frame 16 km across.

Fewer than three memorials stand within 3 km of the study area, so the nearest ones within 8 km are listed.

	Memorial	Disaster	Erected	Distance
1	Memorial to the victims of the landslide of June 1965 慰霊碑	Debris flow (20 Jun 1965) · landslide or debris flow	1966	2.4 km
2	Monument honouring Segawa Uichi for the recovery from the 1926 and 1928 floods 瀬川卯一翁彰徳碑	Floods and debris flows (1926 and 1928) · flood / landslide or debris flow	1943	5.1 km
3	Memorial to the 1926 flood of the Enokawa and other rivers 水害記念碑	Flood and debris flows (11 Sep 1926) · flood / landslide or debris flow	1944	5.2 km
4	Monument to the 2014 Hiroshima landslide disaster 広島土砂災害	Heavy rain of August 2014 (Hiroshima landslides, 20 Aug 2014) · landslide or debris flow	2014	5.5 km
5	Monument to the flood and debris flows of September 1926 水害碑	Flood and debris flows (11 Sep 1926) · flood / landslide or debris flow	1930	5.8 km

What the memorials record

1. **Memorial to the victims of the landslide of June 1965.** Erected in a corner of a park at the foot of Hiji-yama hill to honor those who died in a landslide on 20 June 1965.
2. **Monument honouring Segawa Uichi for the recovery from the 1926 and 1928 floods.** The inscription records the causes and damage of the floods and debris flows brought by torrential rain in 1926 and 1928, and the work of Segawa, head of Yamamoto village at the time, in the recovery.
3. **Memorial to the 1926 flood of the Enokawa and other rivers.** Torrential rain on 11 September 1926 flooded the Enokawa and other rivers. Embankments broke along about 6.4 km and more than 20 bridges were washed away; 3 people died, 26 houses were swept away and 101 were half-destroyed.
4. **Monument to the 2014 Hiroshima landslide disaster.** A red line carved on the monument marks the height of 62 cm above the ground reached by the debris flow of 20 August 2014, passing on to future generations what happened in the disaster.
5. **Monument to the flood and debris flows of September 1926.** The inscription, in classical Chinese, describes the flood and debris flows caused by torrential rain on 11 September 1926 and the damage they did.

Source: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑). English names and notes are Japan Time Atlas translations and summaries of GSI's Japanese descriptions; the memorials' own inscriptions may say more. "Erected" is the year GSI records for the monument.

Where every element comes from

- **Aerial photographs** (pp. 2–3) — Geospatial Information Authority of Japan (GSI), GSI Tiles: series *ort_USA10* (1945–1950, US military photography), *ort_old10* (1961–1969), *gazo1* (1974–1978), *gazo2* (1979–1983), *gazo4* (1987–1990) and *nendophoto2023*. Cropped, resized and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. List of GSI Tiles: <https://maps.gsi.go.jp/development/ichiran.html>
- **Landform classification** (pp. 4–5) — GSI landform-classification vector tiles (natural and artificial landforms), compiled by GSI from its Land Condition Maps, Flood Control Terrain Classification Maps and vulnerable-landform surveys. Rendered, measured and translated into English by Japan Time Atlas. https://github.com/gsi-cyberjapan/experimental_landformclassification
- **Meiji-era lowland** (p. 5) — GSI “明治期の低湿地” tiles and legend (https://maps.gsi.go.jp/legend/lw_legend.pdf), measured and translated by Japan Time Atlas.
- **Natural disaster memorials** (p. 6) — GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑), registered by municipalities, <https://www.gsi.go.jp/bousaichiri/denshouhi.html>; processed by Japan Time Atlas (selection by distance, English translation and summary). Memorial photographs are not reproduced.
- GSI content is used under the GSI Content Terms of Use, which follow the Public Data License v1.0 (PDL1.0, compatible with CC BY 4.0). Data retrieved 2026-09-27.
- **Outline of Japan** — Data of Japan / JapanPrefGeoJson (public domain), simplified.

Method

The study area is a fixed rectangle of 2.0 × 1.3 km. Every GSI photo series that covers at least 85% of it is included; the newest annual orthophoto covering at least 90% of it is used as “now”, with any gap filled from GSI's latest seamless mosaic. Landform shares are areas of the rectangle measured on GSI's polygons at zoom level 14, each class merged before measuring. Meiji-era shares count map pixels by legend color. Memorials are selected by straight-line distance from the center of the study area.

Limits

Historical series are mosaics of photographs taken on different dates; GSI publishes the flight date of each photograph. Landform data record conditions at the time of survey. Nothing in this brief shows present-day access, safety or opening hours.

Area Dossier. The same district with a 4–8 page English history, written from Japanese library sources and cited page by page.

Deep Research. A single hamlet or address, researched in libraries and archives.

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